

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

VA puts outreach program on hold

Aldermen: Cuts to fed agencies come home to city's ward offices

By Talia Soglin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

When Ald. Matt O'Shea walked into his 19th Ward office Wednesday morning, he saw five veterans in line waiting for one-on-one support from the Department of Veterans Affairs.

The former service members come from all over the Chicago area every week to get help securing health care, employment, disability pay and other benefits during the support sessions staffed by VA workers, O'Shea said. But Wednesday marked a sudden, unexpected last day for the program, he said.

Sweeping cuts to federal agencies made by President Donald Trump's administration appeared to come home to ward offices across Chicago, as O'Shea and several other members of the City Council told the Tribune they'd been notified by the VA that it was "temporarily" pausing the outreach.

"Veterans served their country," O'Shea said. "And they didn't turn their back on us. They were there, protecting the freedom we all enjoy. Now, the government is turning their back on veterans. What message does it send?"

The pause in help came as news broke that the Department of Veterans Affairs planned to undertake a sweeping reorganization that would include slashing around 80,000 agency jobs.

"To ensure we provide the highest level of care where needed most, we must temporarily pause our comprehensive outreach program," a letter sent to aldermen and reviewed by the Tribune read.

"We understand this is short notice and sincerely wish there was more time to prepare for this transition. However, after careful evaluation, it became clear that immediate action was necessary to ensure that our Veterans receive the highest level of care in the areas where they need it most. This decision was not made lightly," the email read.

Ald. Gilbert Villegas, a Marine Corps veteran who helped spread the outreach program that he said

Turn to Cuts, Page 5

IN NATION & WORLD:

President Donald Trump is granting U.S. automakers a one-month exemption on his tariffs on imports from Mexico and Canada. **Business, Page 4**

■ According to an internal memo, the VA is planning a reorganization that includes cutting over 80,000 jobs. **Business, Page 5**



Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson, center, is sworn in with Denver Mayor Mike Johnston and Boston Mayor Michelle Wu in front of the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform on Wednesday in Washington. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Johnson defends Chicago's sanctuary laws at hearing

Mayor spars with congressional Republicans trying to paint city as lawless

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

WASHINGTON — Mayor Brandon Johnson defended Chicago's sanctuary policy for immigrants Wednesday inside the U.S. Capitol, sparring for hours with congressional Republicans who sought to paint the nation's third-largest city as lawless under his leadership.

During the marathon GOP-led hearing, Johnson delivered a forceful endorsement of Chicago's long history as a haven for

immigrants — against a backdrop of heavy political theater over one of the country's most divisive issues.

Seated in the middle of a five-person witness panel with the Democratic leaders from three other major U.S. cities, Johnson touted Chicago's downward trend in crime in his opening statement. He went on to argue throughout the six-hour session that the city's long-standing policy blocking local police from assisting in federal immigration enforcement in fact

makes communities safer.

"I know there are myths about these laws," Johnson said in his opening remarks to the U.S. House Oversight and Government Reform Committee. "But we must not let mischaracterizations and fearmongering obscure the reality that Chicago's crime rates are trending down. We still have a long way to go, but sensationalizing tragedy in the name of political expediency is not governing. It's grandstanding."

The mayor also invoked Chicago's Black history, shouting out

its Haitian founder, the explorer Jean Baptiste Point DuSable, and his Potawatomi wife before ending his opening remarks by reciting his common slogan with a twist: "Better, stronger, *much* safer Chicago."

The appearance by the first-term Chicago mayor at the much-hyped hearing gave Johnson a national audience to defend the sanctuary city policies that block local police from assisting in immigration enforcement. It was

Turn to Hearing, Page 5

Supreme Court rejects freeze on foreign aid

Bid to halt nearly \$2B by Trump falls in narrow 5-4 vote

By Adam Liptak
The New York Times

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Wednesday rejected President Donald Trump's emergency request to freeze nearly \$2 billion in foreign aid in a closely divided decision indicating that the justices will

subject his efforts to reshape the government to close scrutiny.

The court's brief order was unsigned, which is typical when the justices act on emergency applications. It said only that the trial judge, who had ordered the government to resume payments, "should clarify what obligations the government must fulfill."

But the ruling represented one of the court's first moves in response to the flurry of litigation filed in response to Trump's efforts to slash government

spending and take complete control of the executive branch. The vote was 5-4, with Chief Justice John Roberts and Justice Amy Coney Barrett joining the three liberal members to form a majority.

Although the language of the order was mild, tentative and not a little confusing, its bottom line was that a bare majority of the court ruled against Trump on one of his signature projects. The

Turn to Court, Page 9



President Donald Trump greets Supreme Court Chief Justice John Roberts in the House Tuesday night. **SAUL LOEB/GETTY-AFP**



Naomi Davis, founder and CEO of Blacks in Green, walks around one of the Chicago alleys where her organization is planning a four-block geothermal network on Feb. 14. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Geothermal project may offer hope

Clean energy source will heat and cool West Woodlawn homes

By Nara Schoenberg
Chicago Tribune

You can heat homes with gas, propane, oil or electricity.

Or you can make use of the virtually endless supply of clean energy that lies right beneath your feet.

The South Side nonprofit Blacks in Green is pursuing the latter option, with a plan for a multi-building geothermal system that will tap steady, year-round underground temperatures of about 55

degrees.

In step one of the project, workers will send plastic pipes 450 feet into the ground beneath Chicago alleys. The pipes, which circulate a fluid that absorbs and releases heat, will loop back to up to 69 buildings in a four-block area of West Woodlawn, powering heating and central air.

The \$10.8 million project is one of only five community geothermal heating plans nationwide selected for full funding by the Department of Energy in December, and it is moving forward at a time of growing interest in neighborhood geothermal among states, utilities and energy experts.

"It will be an example for the entire country," said Tugce Baser, an associate professor of civil engineering at Saint Louis University and a member of the Blacks in Green project team.

It's unclear whether the project will be affected by President Donald Trump's attempts to freeze funding for clean energy programs, but Blacks in Green founder and CEO Naomi Davis said her team is assuming the best and continuing its work on the project.

Multibuilding geothermal heating and cooling has been used for decades, often at college campuses

Turn to Geothermal, Page 2

Setting 'a new precedent'

Some school board members concerned about vote that kept five Acero schools open. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Habitat Co. sues CHA

The real estate firm alleges mishandling and malpractice of lead poisoning legal action. **Business**

Just a short-term fix?

Brad Biggs' thoughts on Joe Thuney and the Bears' offensive line overhaul. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 43 Low 33

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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